Forum 2: On Coding with Wisdom and Justice

Week 4

Group members: _____

_____

Before class: *Read On Coding with Wisdom and Justice.*

In class: *You'll receive a paper with the discussion questions below. In small groups, talk through the questions, annotate the paper with your group's thinking, and compare notes with another group. Before you leave, take a photo of your annotated paper (with everyone's name on it) and upload it to Moodle.*

Discussion Questions

1. The article opens with Indiana's welfare system automatically denying over a million aid applications because the algorithm couldn't handle context the way a human caseworker could. Where do you see `if`/`else`-style rules at work in that failure? What context might be hard to capture in a simple condition?

2. Michael Polanyi's idea of *tacit knowledge* is that "we know more than we can tell." Can you think of a decision you make in daily life that would be hard to write as a precise `if` statement, because so much of your judgment is intuitive?

3. Drawing on Wittgenstein, the author argues that "any course of action can be made out to accord with the rule" — meaning rules always need interpretation in context. As you write conditionals this week, where do you find yourself making a judgment call about what a condition "really" means?

4. The author suggests two questions programmers should ask about any algorithm: *what context does this algorithm assume?* and *what conditions would break it?* Pick an app or algorithm you use daily (a spam filter, a recommendation feed, a grade calculator) and try answering both.

Submission

Take a photo of your group's annotated discussion paper — make sure every group member's name is on it — and upload it to Moodle by the end of class.